Mujahid, who headed MDI's Public Relations Department and was Lashkar's lead spokesperson, said the report was part of a propaganda campaign by *Agence France-Presse* and *CNN* to malign the group. He asserted that not only was Lashkar exclusively focused on fighting to liberate Indian-administered Kashmir, but that it also never targeted civilians. Mujahid expressed Lashkar's regret for the loss of lives and property in the attacks.[41] Saeed reinforced this message two months later, stating 'We may differ with US policy, and that is our right, but we do not mean any harm to any US citizen or property.'[42]

Saeed was sending mixed messages however. He became a high profile spokesman in the public campaign against the US run by the Pak-Afghan Defence Council, which had been founded the previous December to protest UN-supported sanctions against the Taliban. Saeed warned the West that it would face the 'cohesive strength of the Muslims,' exhorted his countrymen to prepare for jihad against the enemy forces and saluted the Afghans for protecting bin Laden.[43] An MDI mufti, Abdur Rehman al-Rahmani, went further and issued a fatwa decreeing that the entire umma, especially Pakistan, was obliged to support bin Laden and Afghanistan against an American attack. It stated that a US invasion would be the beginning of a war between Islam and the kuffaar in which all Muslim states were required to fight. Asserting that Pakistan's raison d'être was the protection of Islam, it warned that if Pakistan's leaders sided with America then 'they would be treated as rebels of Allah.'[44] For all its impassioned rhetoric during the ensuing months, however, Lashkar's focus remained fighting against India. Three days after the 9/11 attacks Saeed pledged the Pakistani people would not abandon the Afghans in the 'present hour of trial and would fully stand behind them.'[45] Then, a week later, he denied Lashkar was shifting its fighters to Afghanistan and instead promised to carry the jihad further inside India.[46] As it turned out, JeM militants delivered the next strike to the Indian hinterland.

On 13 December 2001 gunmen infiltrated the grounds of Parliament House in New Delhi. Although the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha [the Upper and Lower Houses, respectively] were adjourned, many Members of Parliament and other government officials were still in the building. All of them escaped alive, but five policemen, a security guard and a gardener were killed, as were five Jaish militants. India initially accused JeM and